Shifting Allegiances

- Having masterminded the creation of the INDIA bloc and successfully rallying opposition parties against the BJP in 2023, Nitish Kumar made a surprising political shift in 2024; he ended his alliance with the RJD-led Grand Alliance and rejoined the BJP-led NDA in January
- In this year's Lok Sabha polls, Nitish's JD(U) not only matched the BJP's seat count in Bihar but also emerged as a key player with 12 MPs, proving essential for the BJP's survival at the Centre
- Positioned as a kingmaker, Nitish used his newfound clout to secure special schemes for Bihar in the Union Budget
- Under Nitish's leadership, the NDA swept four critical by-elections in November

Remember Ellsworth Toohey, the fictional character in *The Fountainhead* who could win both sides of the debate on 'The pen is mightier than the sword'? Well, Nitish Kumar, the man who can spin the *chakra* of Indian politics on both his hands, is an improvement on Ayn Rand's socialist. He can speak truth to power, as well as the truth of power. His pen writes in invisible ink, and he has no need for a sword—a razor-sharp eye on the main chance suffices. The word 'mercurial' is often applied because of his quicksilver shifts, being the inventor of a grand Opposition alliance one day and the cause of the ruling party's greatest comfort the next day. Or the idea that he tells the temperature accurately. But like the metal, he's not without density and weight, and in fact often sets the temperature merely by his foretelling. And like the planet, he prefers being closest to the Sun. India's political galaxy, as it took a bet on its future with a general election in mid-2024, found its new shape by the gravity of his placement within it. To that extent, he's as much the scriptwriter of Modi 3.0 as he was of the INDIA bloc. Two back-to-back hits in two years on the national stage. Not to speak of Bihar, over which he has defied prophecies of senescence to extend his lease indefinitely.

Exactly down the middle of January, the usual choreography of camaraderie saw the Bihar chief minister walk from his official residence to that of Lalu Prasad Yadav, for the traditional Makar Sankranti feast. The usual optics followed; Nitish partook of a modest helping of *dahi-chura* before making a quiet exit within 20 minutes, leaving behind a cloud of speculation. Still, what followed was a twist nobody saw coming. Thirteen days later, on January 28, his alliance with the RJD and Congress stood dissolved. The man who had brought together all anti-BJP parties for a national electoral confederation was suddenly on the other side. A pro forma resignation as CM, a new swearing-in and cabinet, this time an NDA one, and Nitish demonstrated his ambidexterity once again. It was risky. Soothsayers wrote him off, placing him on the wrong end of the BJP's use-and-discard politics after the Lok Sabha polls. In the end, the JD(U) was holding a crucial dozen seats—and the BJP needed his helping hand to climb back up over the cliff. Ensconced thus as kingmaker, Nitish leveraged his newfound clout to secure special schemes for Bihar in the Union Budget—his "pound of flesh," as some called it, a bit uncharitably.

By year-end, Nitish's political resurgence was complete. The BJP has shelved its solo ambitions and named him the face of NDA for Bihar '25

Of all the pivots he has performed, this might have been the most pivotal—and breathtaking. It restored the stature he appeared to lose in the 2020 assembly elections when the JD(U) finished a distant third, winning just 43 seats in the 243-member house. In the summer of 2024, we found Nitish's party leading in 74 assembly segments, ahead of the BJP's 68 and leagues beyond the RJD's 35. By year-end, his political resurgence was complete. After Nitish steered the NDA to victory in all four November byelections, the BJP quietly shelved its *atmanirbharta* project and declared him the face of the NDA for the 2025 assembly polls in Bihar. That will be one of Nitish's nine lives. ■